

Kol Hashem ba-Koach

On Our "Red Lines" in Heeding the Word of God

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Two difficult questions, ones that have long circled within the space of my inner religious life, pushed me to write the essay before you. The first question concerns places where the rabbinic interpretation — of the Oral Torah — of the verses and commandments that appear in the Torah seems to have drifted too far from what I understand immediately when I read the Written Torah itself. This includes workarounds, forced readings (*ukimtot*), or excuses, all of which leave me with the feeling that we are abandoning the original meaning of our traditions and sacred texts and setting off on other paths. The second question concerns situations in which it is clear to me that I will not be able to fulfill the letter of the *halakha*, and that I will not be able, in all honesty, to feel regret over that; situations in which the *halakha* collides with spiritual instincts deeply rooted in me, above all in cases of moral taboo. Though the two questions inhabit two different worlds (the collective Jewish-traditional world, and the personal spiritual world), they converge, for me, on a single point, a single question, asked out of a sudden, bottomless honesty that strikes me — namely, how open are we, in truth, to divine revelation?

A. Light, Vessel, Contraction

One of the metaphors common in kabbalistic literature is that of light and vessels. The light-and-vessels metaphor in fact describes a relationship parallel to the one we mean by the terms "body and soul," in their simplest and most common sense — except that it lets us sketch that relationship in a richer, more complex way. Through it we more easily picture the "blinding" — and hence the impossibility — of the bare light appearing as it truly is; the abstractness and subtlety of light relative to the material, spatial vessel, which strikes us as more "real," even if cruder; the fact that a vessel can be emptied and filled, and can go on being filled, endlessly, with more of the pure, placeless light; the idea that a greater number of vessels capable of receiving the light produces a fuller and more varied appearance of it, even though the original light is uniform, simple and unchanging; and so on.

This essay is focused on a particular facet of the complexity in the relationship between light and vessels. To explain what I mean, let me first cite a parable from the Alter Rebbe [Rabbi Shneur Zalman of Liadi]:

A teacher who conveys understanding to his student — when he needs to convey that understanding to him — must descend from his own level and constrict his intellect to the vessel of comprehension available to the student... For at first, when

the student receives the imparted understanding, he does not yet grasp it in its depth; that is, his grasp of it is only general, without differentiating so as to discern all its parts and the reasoning behind each point individually. Hence that understanding, in its generality, only encompasses the student's mind from outside... But afterward, once the student meditates on the flow of understanding and penetrates to its depth and grasps it well, then, on the contrary, his mind comes to encompass that very flow of understanding, so that it enters him as, in effect, inner light...

Likkutei Torah, p. 37, column 3

The action the teacher performs so that the student will understand his words can be called, in kabbalistic terminology, "the contraction (tzimtzum) of light." The teacher's understanding, which resides hidden within the teacher in its full breadth and depth, cannot simply "pass over" and be received by the student as it is, since it does not fit the student's vessel of reception. In our case, the teacher himself decides to lower the message to the student's level ("to constrict his intellect to the vessel of the student's comprehension"). But in fact, one can see that in any exchange between teacher and student, a kind of transformation of the "light" necessarily occurs — from the aspect of "simple light," the light of clear understanding as it exists at its source in the teacher, to the "contracted" aspect, the aspect of the student's understanding as shaped by his own world, concepts and mental level ("inner light"). The content conveyed is necessarily pictured and formed differently in the recipient; and if the teacher is wiser and more broad-minded, then necessarily this re-formation will also be, in a certain sense, a contraction and diminishment of the content. This is a process that underlies any dialogue whatsoever.

This idea appears in the words of our sages regarding the Sinai revelation:

"For who is there of all flesh that has heard the voice of the living God speaking out of the fire, as we have, and lived" [Deut. 5:23]. How did the voice go forth? To each and every one of Israel according to his strength (koach) — the elders according to their strength, the young men according to their strength, the little ones according to their strength, the infants according to their strength, and the women according to their strength, and even Moses according to his strength, as it is said, "Moses spoke, and God answered him with a voice" [Ex. 19:19] — with a voice he was able to bear. And so it says, "the voice of the LORD is baKoach" [Ps. 29:4] — it does not say "in His strength," but "baKoach" — in the strength of each and every one; and even pregnant women, according to their strength. Hence it is said: each and every one according to his strength.

Shemot Rabbah (Vilna), 5:9

The divine voice as it truly is, "in God's own strength," cannot be heard by a human ear — not even by Moses our teacher, of whom it is said, "I speak with him mouth to mouth" [Num. 12:8], and whose prophecy our sages likened to a shining mirror. Revelation is always "each and every

one according to his strength" — it never departs from the general rules of dialogue, according to which there will always be a gap between speaker and listener, between the "light" at its source and the "light" as it exists within its "vessel."

The image of teacher and student from the passage of the Alter Rebbe cited above will help us understand the next stage of the argument, if we translate it into the relation between father and son. Let us picture a child whom, from his earliest years, his father educates toward a certain worldview, or to whom he repeats, again and again, short, meaning-laden messages — slogans, if we set aside the negative connotations now attached to that word. Even if the father goes on saying the very same things throughout the whole span of the child's upbringing, what the child receives from them will keep changing according to his stage in life. When he is small he will understand one thing; later he will grow, and be able to understand deeper layers, sometimes changing entirely the initial meaning out of which he grew. At every stage of the child's development, the substrate onto which the content is received — the sum of thoughts, experiences and insights the child already possesses — looks different, and in light of that sum, the interpretation of the message is reshaped and altered. The vessel is not a static concept; it is dynamic, developing, expanding and changing shape — and so, too, the light within it differs, even though the source remains the same.

One can say, in a certain sense, that the Written Torah expresses the "simple light" — the light as it exists at its complete and absolute divine source — while the Oral Torah expresses the "inner light," the light as it exists according to our own strength. The Oral Torah is simply everything that we, the addressees of the Torah, read into the Written Torah and realize in our lives. The Oral Torah is the translation of the divine Torah into human understanding, the passage from the primal, heavenly message — which exists in raw and holy form within the letters of the Torah — into concrete realization within a real-world matrix of facts and contexts. The people of Israel are the vessel: the way in which we, as a nation, understand and interpret the Torah is the only divine message that can ever reach us.[1] But the nation is no static medium,[2] the people of Israel is a living, active body, with a history and a politics, involved in what happens in the world, facing its own cultural and national struggles. It is not for nothing that what binds us is the Oral Torah — one cannot take a literal message, rigid, final and one-time, and found upon it the life of generations: a full life branching into countless domains and authorities, dilemmas and values, situations and concepts; a life that walks alongside history, a developing life, a life whose very essence is movement and change. That is why the Oral Torah is a developing Torah; it is built, layer upon layer, by the sages of every generation, with the formulation relevant to the letter of the law always being the most recent one for the present time — "to the judge who shall be in those days" (cf. Deut. 17:9).

B. The Drive to Open toward the Divine, the Survival Instinct, and the System of Interpretive Mediation

The heart of religiosity springs from a hidden insight, an insight of the heart, according to which the more a person opens his world to a divine component — a revelatory, transcendent component located outside himself — broadly and comprehensively, the more, in that same measure, his life is elevated and gains its splendor, its meaning, its happiness, its anchor. Life is justified through this opening, through accepting the yoke of the Kingdom of Heaven, through introducing a non-egoistic component into the engine of life — and the more dominant that component is, the more life is justified. This is the religious intuition, and it stands at the base of the free decision to accept the yoke of the Kingdom of Heaven and the yoke of the commandments, more than any theological understandings or belief in the traditional-religious principles that underlie them. This is the divine sense within a person, one that can easily be blocked by coarse sensuality, desire, low self-centeredness and all the branches of life dragged along with them — but it is there, in the depth of the soul, always.

This opening becomes "more effective" the more the reception, understanding and internalizing of the message happen through as few filters as possible. The more the element of accepting the yoke grows, the more we are willing to accept the command as it plainly is, without embellishment, without the mediation of our moral understanding or our practical or psychological constraints — the more life is bound to the supernal holiness, the more it fills with a supreme vitality, an air of nobility that is, for the soul, like oxygen. The more it distances itself from rootlessness, from the sealed self-enclosure that suffocates anyone with a heart of flesh within him. Our inner aspiration, then, is upward, toward absolute opening — and this is the central movement that characterizes our religious world.

The Oral Torah is directed, in its entirety, toward hearing the true word of God — pure, precise, as it appeared at Sinai. Yet, as stated above, the arrival of the divine into the human domain — even when it is directed toward a relationship of command, subjection and submission — is necessarily, by definition, a lowering of it into a human "transcription," into "inner light." But beyond this — the vessel's capacity to absorb is limited not only by its essential nature as a vessel, but also by specific, local limitations bearing on all its traits, both the essential and the incidental and transient. This is not necessarily a matter of sin or an exceptional flaw — as stated in the midrash,[3] it was always, in part, the divine principle to let the ear hear only what it is capable of hearing.

There are cases in which the sense of life insists, forcefully, that it cannot accept the message as it plainly stands, in its original appearance. There are commands and messages that the nation of Israel, out of its real, lived life, cannot in the present accept — whose sound its ear cannot hear. Messages that would threaten its very national existence, or would undermine, in an impossible way, the foundations of collective life — whether cultural or factual foundations — simply remain outside the range of the possible, like sound waves pitched higher than the human ear can register. The psychological explanation for this is simple: since the basic will on which the entire religious inclination rests is a will to build life and advance it toward the summit of its noblest possibility, a will to raise life and bind it to the holy and sublime source of the life of life, to gain validation and true justification for life — that very will cannot, itself, rise up and

threaten the very continuation of life's continuity. Just as our physical organism has a survival instinct, so too our conscious-spiritual life has a survival instinct — a survival expressed in the principle of a certain minimal continuity between the "self" before some experiential upheaval and the "self" after it. In places where there is a clash between the original sense of the revelation addressed to us and that survival instinct of our spiritual essence, what happens is a refining and "filtering" of the revelation, into a message that can more readily be voiced and absorbed within the course of life and the character of the identity of the one who receives the revelation — in our case, the living nation of Israel. It should of course be understood that the survival principle, which comes to its sharpest and most blunt expression in situations of extreme clash, is a graduated (differential) principle: the more the vital damage to the sense of life's continuation penetrates, the wider the room for interpretive maneuver will be.

In this way one can explain those specific places where the Oral Torah's understanding diverged from what would seem, at first or more straightforward reading, to follow from the revelatory sources — sometimes because of moral constraints, and sometimes because of real-world constraints: political, social, economic, and so on. The continuity of Jewish existence, with everything this continuity vitally requires in various aspects of that existence, has always been a core value, an inner overriding principle which, in the hidden depths of interpretive and halakhic effort, outweighed all other ideals.[4]

It should be understood: in using the term "moral constraints," I do not mean to claim that our moral outlook will always have the upper hand and dictate the relevant interpretation of the revelation. The value of openness to revelation is greater than the standing of our moral conception, and from a broad perspective, the place given to this value is more central and far-reaching than any other matter in our world. But in specific, pointed cases, the threat that revelation poses to morality as we perceive it constitutes, for us, an existential threat; our personality could not go on grasping itself through the same tools, could not relate to itself by the same yardsticks and foundational concepts, were we to carry out, by our own hand, an act that is anti-moral, as apparently demanded of us by what is revealed to us from the divine; the divine concept itself, if we use it to obligate us to do what is, from our own vantage point, absolute evil, will become so distorted in our eyes that we will no longer be able to make any living, healthy use of it.[5] The rift, then, between our personality — its self-conception, its values and its yardsticks — and the divine matter revealed in the Torah would be, God forbid, a rift that is nearly impossible to mend. We are compelled, therefore, to act so as to avoid such a rift at any cost — and not necessarily through conscious activity.[6]

C. On the Plane of the Individual Person

From this psychological explanation — once we see that it does a good job of describing the interpretive freedom that tradition made broad, if not uniform, use of throughout the history of the Oral Torah, in order to fold into the living national body the messages forced upon it by external divine revelation — one can extrapolate to explain the individual person's encounter with revelation. The individual's encounter with revelation is not necessarily in a prophetic

experience; rather, for us, it is his primary encounter with the texts of the Written and Oral Torah, or with Torah- and halakha-based messages, in places where that encounter calls upon him to deviate and diverge from where he stands, from his own understandings and habits. In every such encounter, a person effectively has a choice — how far to open himself, how far to admit into his life, into his considered judgments and into the forces that drive him, "foreign," external elements;^[7] by the power of such an admission, to crown his life in majesty and splendor and to grant it justification and meaning, but at the same time to harm the fabric of personality and life as he knows them. The decision between the two sides of this choice is not binary and polar — either opening oneself completely or sealing oneself completely. The two sides are mediated through the interpretive space — how much to cling precisely to the initial, "revelatory" understanding, which carries a higher sense of certainty regarding its divine source and is therefore more useful for the religious function of elevating life, which is its inner, subconscious purpose — and how much to maneuver, refine, interpret, "establish" and contextualize the statement, thereby softening its reformatory effects on one's worldview and life. But in the end, the decision remains a decision of free choice; it remains a religious trial, a test. Our aspiration, of course, is to rise as high as we can toward "the divine point of view," to accept the word of God as openly, purely and sincerely as we can — yet there is no doubt that, on the other side, we must not erase the foundations of our existing "self" at any cost — "and he shall live by them" [Lev. 18:5]. This maneuvering — the more we push ourselves to the edge of our capacity, striving and exerting ourselves and truly stepping outside ourselves as far as we are able — is legitimate; it is called for, and it is part of the original divine plan, which created the human being and his religious capacities in just this way.

Of course, the definition of this "capacity" is entirely contingent,^[8] and there is no way to legislate a general law for it that would hold for all values, all people or all situations. But in retrospect, when a person seeks to know whether what he did was done out of excessive weakness and a "closing off" before something higher, at a point when he ought to have opened himself — this is the yardstick: whether forcing himself to accept the message at its most "revelatory" level would have done more damage, at a deeper level, than it would have built; whether the elevated value of the decision to submit to the transcendent in every place is worth the psychic tear that would open up out of the dissonance between the self's own vital necessity and the divine command. At the most extreme edge of such dilemmas, where there is a frontal, explicit and powerful clash between the revelation and the foundations of the personality, there is not even an act of interpretive mediation and refinement;^[9] the person transgresses the command in full, lucid awareness that he is transgressing it, and without any conscious justification for doing so — simply because of the subconscious, inner sense that the religious "benefit," in this case, is smaller than the loss.^[10] I would almost say, "It is a time to act for the LORD; they have violated Your Torah" [Ps. 119:126].

D. Revelation as Part of the Vessel

To sharpen our understanding, we need to note that revelation itself becomes part of the fabric of identity and of the sense of meaning of life. This is so in two senses. The first sense lies in the process by which the content of revelation is internalized. Revelation, once a person has encountered it and been shaped in its light, hardens and becomes bounded; it is "digested" and becomes the person's own "religious outlook," through which and by whose mediation he interprets values and reality. The content of the revelation, which was at first external and foreign, has undergone integration into the earlier contents of the psyche and has been absorbed as a simple and inseparable part of it. From this point on, every fresh piece of "revelation" — that is, every formation of a "renewed" religious insight, whether derived logically from the existing fabric of religious thought, or derived from another, foreign and new source of "experience," such as a suddenly sharp intuition or an encounter with an authoritative revelatory source-text, whose conclusions diverge from the existing "religious outlook" — will always have to reckon, to some degree, with the cognitive filters and interpretive constraints that flow from the centrality of the existing religious outlook within one's personal identity. Let me illustrate: when a boy of twelve or thirteen is first told about the "prohibition on touch" [shemirat negiah], the matter often feels distant and alien to his world. From his vantage point, it is a "revelation" — an obligation landing on him from outside, as the word of God, whose acceptance stems solely from an inner decision to open himself to what lies beyond his personal spiritual world. But after some span of time, and as he grows accustomed to living in a society whose prevailing norm is the observance of shemirat negiah, the value of observing it becomes absorbed into his inner world and becomes part of the contents inherent to his considerations and desires. This is no longer a matter of struggle, nor of submission to the word of God, but, in a certain sense, simply the natural and straightforward conduct of the life that he lives. In this state, should that same young man encounter some new Torah source, one he had not known before, from which it simply follows that touching women is permitted — the matter will not penetrate his world as it stands, but will instead be interpreted, qualified and contextualized, so as to create a renewed harmony through a fitting reconciliation between the new source and his Torah-based intuition, which rests on many other sources. Religious intuition — which stands atop the revelatory sources we have already absorbed into ourselves — is itself part of the filter, part of the boundaries of the vessel.

In the second sense, the place of revelation — or more precisely, of the idea of subjection to the revelatory command — can reach a depth of the inner soul so penetrating and so rooted that it can, in certain places, become identified with the very point of the will to live. This is how one should explain those commandments that override [the preservation of] life — those for which "one must die rather than transgress" — since halakha has defined these commandments as such, the harm caused by transgressing them to the spiritual-religious foundation of life is so deep that life afterward cannot be considered to have justification. This feeling is what underlies martyrdom (mesirut nefesh). But not all parts of the Torah are equal, and not every point of revelation occupies the same place in the personal identity of one who has accepted the yoke of the Kingdom of Heaven.

E. The Problem of Legitimacy

Let us pause for a moment on the concept of legitimacy that I emphasized above.[11] The situation described — of a frontal clash with revelation — is not a situation that can be resolved consciously and transparently; it necessarily brings about a state of "cognitive dissonance." [12] The religious person sets, as a foundational trait of his identity, absolute strictness regarding halakha, and this trait, which decisively shapes how he defines and perceives himself, cannot tolerate any "conscious" transgression of the divine command. "A person does not commit a transgression unless a spirit of folly has entered him"; though this is not always how it feels in the moment of transgression, after every instance in which the religious-halakhic person chooses to sin, he recognizes the "self" that committed the transgression as an inferior "self," a weaker "self," one that does exist within him but does not express his true essence, but rather forces of great power acting within him and at times overpowering him. This is what makes possible the continuity of identity within our field of consciousness. Even though we sin, this sin is not attributed, in our minds, to the plane that is essential to us — to the general, lucid, fully-conscious plane, the plane of our conscious identity — and this is the only way we can cope with our sins successfully and correctly.[13] But what happens at the difficult junctures of clash — whether in the actual encounter with them or in theoretical reflection about them — is, in fact, unresolvable from the conscious point of view. For there are foundational lines within our identity that we have not taken up and made part of our declared identity or our self-definition, and yet they are indeed an inherent and inseparable part of who we are and of how we conduct our lives.

I want to use the example brought in the Gemara: "Rav Yehuda said in the name of Rav: One who finds a garment of kilayim [forbidden mixed fibers] on his body removes it immediately, even in the marketplace — what is the reason? 'There is no wisdom, no understanding and no counsel against the LORD'" [Prov. 21:30] (Berakhot 19b). The personal question that arises upon encountering this ruling — can you testify of yourself that, were you in such a situation, you would carry out this halakhic ruling and walk naked through the marketplace? — is deeply troubling. It seems to me one can say, honestly, that a great many of us would not withstand the test — even people for whom halakhic strictness is, with all their heart, a guiding light. I am not claiming that no one would do it; indeed, whoever would be prepared, in that situation, to do the absolute word of God and walk naked through the market deserves great praise for his devotion to halakha. But his existence does not prove that everyone who does not act this way is "not okay" in some irredeemable sense — that he is weak of character and has no place in the world of the Holy One. And this is not because "a spirit of folly" entered him when he decided to keep wearing the kilayim — it is hard to lie to ourselves and declare that the decision was the fruit of the "evil inclination" or of various low places within us. Here the cognitive dissonance appears in its full force: this is not a decision that stems from "weakness of will" in the familiar sense, yet on the other hand it is starkly clear that God commanded, in His Torah, to act otherwise, and that this transgression cannot have any ideological, a priori justification. The reason I find it hard to attach to this the label of weakness of will or a spirit of folly lies in the

fact that these concepts, by their very definition, seem tied to temporariness — to a momentary eruption of desires from the psychic realm of "chaos" (tohu) that have no true hold in the "higher self," in my principled self-definition and personal identity. Whereas here, my honest awareness will admit that my decision carries no symptom of temporariness whatsoever; I feel, with high certainty, that even if this dilemma arose before me again tomorrow — and more than that, even if I merely raise it in my mind's eye theoretically — my choice would remain the same choice, and therefore this is the decision with which I identify. This is an unresolvable conflict: all the possibilities remain, and will remain, genuinely open before me — since this is not a matter of external coercion, of "rape" (o'nes), which halakha recognizes after the fact — and yet I will choose not to remove the garment, and to live with the sense of illegitimate sin. [14]

Our aspiration is to establish and set up our religious will — the will that drives us to do the word of God — absolutely and uncompromisingly, as the most rooted and most dominant force of life. And yet, our religious will never constitutes the entirety of the layers of our identity, and even if it matters to us more than any other defined ideal or value-principle, this does not mean that we are in a psychic state capable of withstanding any command whatsoever, whatever its psychological and identity-related consequences may be. At every stage of religious development, the religious-revelatory principle, which aspires to absolute, untouched, uninterpreted subjection, conducts a dialogue with the other foundational sides of the personality — whether at a less conscious level or a more conscious one. When we examine this phenomenon from the outside, as descriptive observers, we find it to be absolutely necessary, to the point that there is no meaning in speaking of legitimacy or illegitimacy; this is simply the way to exist religiously. Thus did the Holy One create the relationship with His creatures — "in the strength of each and every one."

F. Practical Implications?

What am I trying to accomplish in the spiritual world by writing these things? What effect do I expect them to have, what impact on religious and psychological life? It is not for nothing that I dwelt on the concept of legitimacy and set it apart from the discussion at hand. The tone of my words could be mistakenly read as an attempt to "permit," or to make more room in our religious world for conscious a-priori transgressions, or for apologetic interpretive maneuvers that, in the currently accepted religious outlook, are illegitimate, such that anyone who admits in advance that these are part of his way is defined as "outside the fold." But that is not my intention; heeding the word of God, which in concrete cases finds expression through halakha, always remains the foundation of our identity as religious, commandment-observant people. But this heeding does not succeed, and is not able, to appear in an absolute and pure way in the realm of our actual practice — it passes through us. We strive to open ourselves to the divine message, but it necessarily passes through our filters, and even if we intend to "bind ourselves upon the altar" and nullify our own world before revelation, we simply do not have that capacity; the personality is not something that can be nullified, it is not some screen that can be

shattered, but rather it is the very vessel through which we exist, here, as God-fearing servants of the LORD. Our personality — which we are ceaselessly shaping, yet which also exists, fixed and specific, at any given moment — is what determines what happens with the message that penetrates the vessel of our consciousness, and that is how it is meant to happen, a priori; that is part of the basic design of the world that the Holy One built. In what I have written, I have not tried to change anything in our halakhic conception or in our normative religious world, but rather to change the way we perceive ourselves and the relationship between us and that religious world to which we sign our absolute commitment.

In practice, one must understand that, much like the aspiration to perfection, the demand to be subject to the divine appearance exactly as it is, absolutely, is a demand that cannot come to full expression in reality. Revelation elevates us, exalts our lives and lifts us to lofty heights we could not have reached on our own; it opens our lives to an eternal dimension, a dimension of absolute, transcendent reality, and pours into them an air of the summits, majesty and meaning. It is effective, in this aim, only if we relate to it with the utmost seriousness, with an awe of grandeur and a love of soul, with devotion (*deveikut*) and dedication. And yet, despite how it may seem at first, it was apparently the Creator's very intention that this not happen through a single, complete, one-time human transformation — which lies beyond the bounds of possible reality — but rather through a process of dialogical advance, in which the human being walks toward the divine, yet at the same time holds on to it and draws upon it in order to keep going on the way.[15]

This model matters because it helps us understand ourselves in areas that lie beyond our "ideological" decisions. There are matters in which, even if we encounter a clear-cut halakha or rabbinic dictum that contradicts what is customary and accepted as correct, we automatically find ways to "cope" with such a dictum, and we do not rush to revise our values and norms in light of what emerges from the source we have encountered. This is not only true when our religious-spiritual world is sufficiently developed and grounded in the sources, in which case it would merely be a rational consideration to suspend the concrete conclusion and see how it might genuinely bear on our understanding of the word of God in light of our overall familiarity with the sources; it is also true when our world is not so grounded, or even when we encounter a more massive sequence of sources that do not align with our religious being. Even then, we move automatically between qualifying, moderating and interpreting the source, on the one hand, and ignoring it or being spiritually indifferent to it, on the other. We do have the option of choosing a more substantial digestion of the new ideas, an attempt to melt them into our concepts, assumptions, outlooks and self-perception, as a slow, non-immediate process — but in equal measure we can also choose not to open ourselves to the disruptive factor at all, and instead entrench ourselves, holding on to the status quo as it is. Once we understand this psychic process thoroughly, the gates of conscious choice open before us.

It is not only unconscious decisions, but also especially extreme cases, that are illuminated more truly in light of the proposed model. Sometimes, in exceptional situations, life itself departs from any "ideology." We try, by positing theoretical dilemmas and discussing them, to arrange all

possible phenomena and experiences according to our principled norms, and thereby to stabilize and clarify, for ourselves, the world in which we live; in light of this attempt, every dilemma in which we would decide to transgress halakha constitutes a refutation of our self-definition as religious, Orthodox people subject to halakha. And yet, religious identity is an "ideological" identity, and therefore it necessarily does not express everything that is in our soul. More than that — we ourselves do not want it to constitute the whole of our essence; we would not want to erase our personality, with its insights, its inhibitions, its moral intuitions and so on, since we know that this is not what the world was created for, nor for this was the Torah given — and just as this is not the case for Judaism as a collective body, so it is not the case for the individual either. The vessel, too, has worth.

Notes

1. Here is the place to note that even of the Written Torah — of its letters and its verses — one cannot say that it is "the divine light as it is." In fact, the divine light as it is, before it enters into any vessels at all, is entirely inconceivable and therefore beyond our capacity to relate to. It is meaningless to say anything about it beyond its existence, because the moment we clothe it in descriptions drawn from our human language, it is no longer light in its purity but light as our vessels of perception, thought and language absorb its essence. Yet the recognition that there exists a divine message beyond our limited grasp is a critical matter. The reason this recognition is so essential is that the divine message is meant to drive humanity, and existence together with it, ever higher throughout the whole of history. Humanity must maintain a dialogue with, an engagement with, and a submission to, the divine message, while at the same time developing and rising infinitely, so that no defined, particular thing — like a fixed, formulated, literal text — will limit it. The divine must appear in consciousness as beyond, as transcendent, yet on the other hand a real bond with it must be made possible — for otherwise it will have no refining, elevating, advancing effect; it will not grant a horizon, and the human being will remain stuck within himself. For this reason we were given a Written Torah, composed according to the prophetic grasp of Moses our teacher. The principle of the Torah's eternity is justified by the belief that Moses' grasp was the highest human grasp ever potentially possible ("and there has not arisen a prophet in Israel like Moses," Deut. 34:10). Our practical obligation is not to the Written Torah but to the Oral Torah; the Written Torah remains as an image, a horizon, a parable for the supernal holiness beyond all things. It maintains the light-and-vessel relationship with the Oral Torah, as a kind of metaphorical model for the light-and-vessel relationship of the pre-verbal divine speech and what is grasped of it in our human world. It is perceived as the absolute divine message as it is, and our psychic and spiritual bond to it is, in truth, of that kind, because this bond is vital for our lives and for our development. Divine transcendence must have a meaningful presence in life and in the world. But in fact, even the Written Torah itself is, in a deeper and more subtle understanding, nothing but a "copy," or an "imprint," or a "transcription," of some "hidden wisdom," of a wordless Torah that preceded the world, of an abstract and transcendent divine light; it, too, is only "according to [Moses'] strength," and not "the voice of the LORD in His own strength."

2. Medium — "1. An intervening substance through which forces or various influences are transmitted. 2. Any one of the means of communication." (Rav-Milim Dictionary)

3. See Mekhilta de-Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai on Ex. 19:18 and Ex. 24:10; Avot de-Rabbi Natan, version A, ch. 2; and elsewhere.

4. There were, indeed, extreme cases in which the mechanisms of mediation and interpretation were unable to meet the challenge and stretch the written words any further. In these cases, the halakhic authorities invoked overriding principles that they would never have considered using except in emergencies — such as "It is a time to act for the LORD; they have violated Your Torah," or the like.

5. One must hold onto, in the background, the insight that the divine matter must necessarily be pictured by us as bound up with the good, upright, worthy and positive sides of reality. Despite the doctrine of negative attributes, we are compelled to color the divine concept in the hues of goodness and morality, of justice, mercy and peace, so that this concept will function correctly and exert its proper influence on our lives. It is indeed true that we should always remember that the divine command stands above natural human morality, just as God Himself stands above His own attributes, which are fashioned from human material alone — yet, at the same time, it is impossible to sever, once and for all, the human depiction of the divine from the human depiction of the good. The religious and the ethical, within the human soul, must join hands and remain interlaced with one another, in their shared struggle against the dark sides of the soul, and in order to lead the human being's existence toward height, nobility and holiness.

6. The use of concepts like "interpretive maneuver" or "halakhic effort" sharply raises the question of the level of awareness involved in the process of interpretive mediation. When a halakhic authority "bends" the plain meaning and arrives at a "softened" or "workable" conclusion in terms of its results, yet strained in terms of its fit with the source — is he aware of the bending he has produced? Can we say that he consciously chooses a strained interpretation in order to achieve goals that lie outside the hermeneutical (interpretive) purpose of understanding the text's intent? Or must the entire process described occur within the decisor's subconscious currents, while the outer surface of his awareness must remain free of any bias or interest, directed straightforwardly and purely toward clarifying the text's sole meaning? Is it even possible that the strain and the bending disappear entirely from the awareness of those who produced them? This question could apply to halakhic midrashim, to the ukimtot [forced harmonizations] the amoraim apply to the words of the tanna'im in the Talmud, or to bold, innovative rulings within the responsa literature.

7. I deliberately wrote "foreign" elements, and not "religious" or "divine" elements. The reason is that, in my view, the psychological effect of elevation and illumination does not come, first and foremost, from the specific contents of revelation, but rather from the very act of opening oneself to a foreign, external component identified with the divine. Foreignness is itself an expression of transcendence; it is what effects consecration, self-transcendence. See below, in the next chapter, on the "digestion" of revelation into a religious outlook — after this digestion, this integration of the content of revelation into the psyche, the religious outlook becomes part of the filtering mechanisms, part of the "vessel" that limits and shapes the reception of the "light" of future revelations.

8. Contingent — conditional, incidental, not absolute; something that may or may not be the case.

9. At most, a person will justify himself to himself with exaggerated meta-halakhic rules such as "a temporary ruling" (hora'at sha'ah) or "a transgression for its own sake" (aveirah lishmah), even when he is aware that these excuses are strained and implausible. In fact, one can see that a concept like "a transgression for its own sake" serves as a kind of last, desperate, rear-guard line of defense for the interpretive system of mediation.

10. I am aware that my use of utilitarian language regarding religious obedience may sound jarring. As people who place absolute subjection to the word of God as expressed in halakha above all else, as an absolute value, it is hard for us to think of this value in terms of gain and loss — even spiritual gain and loss. Subjection is independent of any value external to it; it does not come to advance me spiritually or to benefit me in any respect, but exists for its own sake alone. I identify completely with this view. And yet, alongside the reign of this view at the active, living, principled, unreflective level of consciousness, I step back and examine my own psychic structure from an outside, descriptive, psychological vantage point. From such a vantage point, one committed to clarity and philosophical consistency, the conception of "value" as an act devoid of personal benefit undergoes a conceptual shift. As I understand it, the will is, by definition, a striving for pleasure; types of wills are classified by the types of pleasure they yield. Indeed, there are psychic forces that drive non-egoistic activity — value-based, moral and religious forces — but these, too, belong to the will-system of the soul, and so in all of them one can identify some kind of "pleasure," and define them accordingly. But none of this is meant to claim that there are no essential differences between one will and another, one pleasure and another, or between one "psychic benefit" and another "psychic benefit." The spiritual benefit of the kind I spoke of above is the highest benefit one can aspire to. On the question of intention and the will "for the sake of Heaven," see at length my essay "Le-Shem Shamayim" ["For the Sake of Heaven"], in: Petichta 14, Yeshivat Petach Tikva, 2008.

11. On the previous page. ("This maneuvering — the more we push ourselves to the edge of our capacity, striving and exerting ourselves and truly stepping outside ourselves as far as we are able — is legitimate...")

12. Cognitive dissonance — "A state in which several opinions or beliefs in a person's mind clash with one another, or clash with a certain behavior." (Rav-Milim Dictionary)

13. This is a solution on two levels at once — both the conscious-psychological level, as described above, and the theoretical-philosophical level. On the latter level, this is the popular answer to what is known as "the problem of weakness of will." How can there be a consciousness of sin, or of regret, when there is nothing we do without choosing it — that is, without having wanted it more than we wanted the other options available to us at the time? If so, how does our conduct at the moment of sin differ from our conduct at other times? Why do we cast the concept of "sin" and "weakness of will" onto the former — as though we "failed" and did not fulfill our true will — while we do not apply such a label to other activities, which likewise involve a choice-driven preference of certain desires over others, and where that preference, too, is subject to shifts and reversals across changing times and moods? We are, almost inevitably, led to distinguish between a will that arises from a deeper layer of identity, a will with which our identification is more rooted (at least in the conscious domain), and a will that arises from parts of the self we perceive as more external and "incidental."

14. In the same way, I propose relating to cases where the point of clash is between revelation and a person's inner moral command. In certain respects, this clash, too, should be understood as a clash between "vessel" and "light" — that is, though there is no doubt regarding the superior nature of "light" relative to "vessel," the limitations of the vessel nonetheless carry decisive weight in certain cases. There are things so difficult for us, so far from our nature, that we are simply incapable, in a moral sense, of doing them. Clashes of the moral kind bring about the sharpest cognitive dissonance of all, since here we are not speaking merely of an incidental, external constraining principle of the vessel — something that could be treated as a kind of "psychic coercion" — but of something far more significant to us. Morality is part of our conscious, declared self-definition; it is a matter that we, by our free choice, make into a central and important concern of the soul. Unlike, for instance, the domain of shame, where the inhibition it produces in us is tangible and powerful, almost a physiological instinct, the sense of incapacity in the moral domain is subtler, since it touches finer, more sensitive strands of our psychic makeup. We feel that, on the one hand, we have the possibility of choice in the physical, external sense, yet on the other hand there is some inner prevention, subtle but bottomless, that binds us and removes that possibility from what could even occur to our minds. It is the very subtlety and softness of the moral necessity that gives rise to our guilt, doubt and confusion regarding the question of moral clash. See the following note.

15. A careful reader will notice that I am playing here between two poles. On the one hand, the passages in the last two chapters sound "resigned" (*bedi'avdi*), since I have used a language of necessity and impossibility. On the other hand, I have occasionally sought to depart from a "descriptive," "objective" outlook — one that merely analyzes our psychological situation and claims that we have no other way — in order to grant legitimacy, to give a priori approval, to this situation. This matter is genuinely delicate. The basic structure of the world, in which there are vessels through which alone "light" can appear, is something about which — even though it concerns necessity and limitation — it makes no sense to say that it is merely "after the fact" (*bedi'avad*). This is simply the structure of reality; this is how God created it, ourselves included. What raises the main difficulty, as noted in the previous note, is the moral issue.